visitors: a group of men returning from the Haj pilgrimage, another from Gujarat, a third with letters from Munim Khan, Akbar's easy-going ataliq, who had been left in charge of Kabul and the imperial harem.

It may have been one of those clear, sunny days that grace Delhi in winter, because Humayun chose to meet his visitors on the roof of the Sher Mandal, a squat little tower of red sandstone that the emperor used as a library. Meeting on the roof had another advantage: people gathered in the neighbouring mosque for Friday prayers would be able to catch a glimpse of their ruler. Meetings concluded, Humayun summoned his mathematicians, wanting them to confirm his calculations that Venus would rise that night. If it did, he wanted to use the auspicious hour to hand out promotions.

Humayun was in this cheerful, generous mood as evening began to fall. Thoughts of death, it would seem, had left his mind. 'But now,' writes Nizamuddin, 'a most extraordinary event occurred . . .'

The sudden chill of winter evenings may have pierced the air, and the emperor's coat. Humayun rose and began to climb down the Sher Mandal. He had a staff to help him negotiate the steep and slippery staircase. Just then, the muezzin of that nearby mosque called out the azaan.

'Allah . . . u Akbar!'

Humayun was a pious man. Nizamuddin writes that the padishah would not take God's name until he had performed his *wazu*, ablutions – so much so that he once referred to a man called Abdul Hai as merely 'Abdul' because 'Hai was a name of the Almighty' and Humayun hadn't yet washed.

So, now, as the melodious call for prayer reached him, Humayun bent to kneel in respect. His foot caught in the hem of his coat; his staff slipped. Down fell the emperor, headlong on hard stone, rolling to the end of the stairs. His attendants rushed to their king, his form spreadeagled – or contorted, it might have been – on the ground. A small, ominous trickle of blood began to flow from his right ear.

Humayun means 'the fortunate' – and for all that historians have written wryly of the man who 'tumbled through life, and . . . tumbled out of it',[74] there is no doubt that it was he, of Babur's four sons, who found his fortune. When Humayun held court on his library's sunny roof, two of his brothers